

Back To School

If you've been reading *Digit*, you'll have seen that we place a lot of emphasis on fun with computers, and fun on the Internet. Yes, the Internet is certainly a fun place. But all play and no work is not good, hence this *Fast Track*, which reviews and points you to a large number of educational sites on the Web.

It's a little sad, really, how few of us use the Net for educating ourselves. (This applies to everyone, not just students.) "Infotainment" is what they call it, but we usually skip the "info" part of it.

There are several reasons we decided upon this unconventional *Fast Track*. First, it is, like we said, to bring to your attention the simple fact that the Web can educate. Second, we have tried to point students—from eighth-standard kids right to those in engineering colleges, for example—to useful sites that can complement their textbook reading. And perhaps most important, we're trying to encourage school students to go beyond what their textbooks tell them, and develop a broader perspective on the world. Yes, education is all about increasing your awareness: it doesn't really matter that the GDP of Great Britain was so many dollars in 2002. But when you're exposed to such information—which you'll doubtless forget after a few years—it's your awareness of the world, in a holistic way, that increases.

On a different note, can't you Google and find the information yourselves? You can. But to find the best sites would take quite a bit of time, and we're saving you that labour. Since we've also reviewed the sites we present, you can choose what site you want to spend time on, so you don't end up wasting time on sites that don't really matter.

Some sites we present are strictly functional—they can help you with your exams. Some are broader, and should be given a look in the interest of developing a holistic perspective on things, like we said.

Go ahead, explore what the Web has to offer in terms of free education. And don't forget to write in if you manage to impress your teachers!